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Jean Bach

Jean Bach's passion for jazz has reaped an unexpected benefit for all jazz lovers. As a young woman she followed the Ellington band and became an expert on his music. Her first husband added his love of Basie and together they became amateur jazz historians. Jean gained media experience as producer of "The Arlene Francis Radio Show" and later with her involvement in "The Sound of Jazz" Television series. The famous Esquire *jazz photo of 1959 gave her further opportunity to use her extensive knowledge and connections in the jazz world. She produced the documentary "A Great Day in Harlem," which has been nominated for an Oscar, and brought about a renewed interest in the jazz personalities from that era.* Life *Magazine has re-staged the photo with the eleven remaining members and created a new montage of current jazz stars.*

Jean was interviewed by Monk Rowe in New York City on October 18, 1995.

MR: Good afternoon. We're filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and we have a very interesting guest with us, Ms. Jean Bach. Welcome. This is special because we've had some musicians, we've had musicians' wives and we've had an agent or two, but you're the first film producer and "jazz source" I'm going to call you.

JB: Well that's true, I am in the film business now. But I used to be identified as a fan, and I felt well that's rather important in the equation, you know you need fans. I was profiled in the *New Yorker* magazine in, about a dozen years ago. And the headline was "Fan." And I thought well that's pretty accurate.

MR: It's nice to know a lot about the music — when you get into filming it makes a big difference.

JB: Yeah, well that's actually how I was able to pull the film together more or less, because I had known the people involved for some years.

MR: We should preface that we're going to be talking about "A Great Day In Harlem," which I know most of our viewers will know about already. But I'd like to ask you first how did you become such a fan of jazz music?

JB: Well I used to use that line, "why did you join the Communist Party?" "To meet girls." I mean in my day, when I got interested in jazz it was mostly, there weren't too many females involved. It was kind of fun.

MR: A good ratio.

JB: Yeah. When I was still in prep school, Billie Holiday came to the Grand Terrace in Chicago. And some fellows took me out to see her. And then I went to Vassar. And Easter week of that first year I went down to the University of Virginia for some dances, and Count Basie's orchestra — now this was 1937, Easter week — and Basie's orchestra and there was Billie Holiday singing with the band. So I thought well I'll get friendly

with her. So I followed her into the ladies room, and I said, "Miss Holiday how wonderful to see you, I saw you at the Grand Terrace last summer." I thought she'd be so impressed that I'd been to the Grand — 'cause it was kind of out-of-the-way in Chicago, you didn't just always go there. And she fluffed me off. She tossed her curls and had nothing to do with me. I probably saw all the important Basie people, you know of the era, but I was a kid and I didn't really, the only one I remember vividly I think I asked Basie who the drummer was, because he was marvelous when he played, you couldn't take your eyes off him, Jo Jones. But you know I was thinking coming up just now I probably saw Herschel Evans, I probably saw all these marvelous people. And yet I can't remember that. The last time I saw Basie was a dance I gave with a friend of mine, about ten, eleven years ago. Bobby Short, who is my oldest friend and I, we were celebrating having known each other for 40 years and we gave a dance, and Basie, thank heaven was still with us. He was in a wheelchair by then, but he wheeled himself over to the piano and then they kind of got him on the piano bench and he did a graceful little toast. And the stuff sounded marvelous. It sounded good. My late husband, Bob Bach, had started out as, he was a jazz fan. And when he was in his teens I think he had a disc jockey show on WNEW, which was kind of a quasi jazz station in those days. They played popular music. And he called the program "Jive at Five" because it was 5:00. So Sweets Edison, he was very friendly with the band. Every time he'd see Basie he'd say "C.B." and then Basie would say "double B" and they'd embrace and all that. And so Sweets wrote a tune for the program and called it "Jive at Five." So you still hear it around, I mean it's still played, but the night of our dance, Basie got out the charts, the parts, you know handed them out and they played that. It was very sweet.

MR: That's marvelous.

JB: Yeah.

MR: So you saw the Basie band through kind of many manifestations?

JB: Oh, yeah. As a matter of fact my first husband was a musician. Both of my husbands are dead so, too bad they can't correct anything I'm going to say that's a mistake. But he had been a jazz trumpet player inspired by Roy Eldridge in his later years, and he formed a little band, and it was a mixed band. And the tenor player was insane about Lester Young. And everybody called him the "Vice Prez," Paul Quinichette.

MR: Oh, yes.

JB: And he started with Shorty Sherock's little orchestra. So then he got, you know, his dream came true, he got to work with Basie too. A lot of wonderful people went through that band.

MR: And for a short time he had a small group too.

JB: Yes. Well that was a heartbreak at first for him, because I think Norman Granz who was you know a genius about money, I think he thought that the small group would probably pay off better and they eliminated Freddie Green and Basie got apoplectic because that was his heartbeat. And so they finally rectified that.

MR: Well this morning we had Bill Crow. And in his book he tells this little story about shortly after that small group went out that Freddie Green showed up at a gig and just set his stuff up and said "you're not leaving me behind."

JB: Oh, that's how he — oh —

MR: "I gave you the best years of my life."

JB: Absolutely.

MR: And there he stayed.

JB: Oh, well, Basie was insane about him. Bob Bach played on their baseball team in Central Park. You know how bands had baseball teams in the old days?

MR: Tell us about that.

JB: Well I wasn't there, it was before I came into Bob's life, but my favorite thing was he said Lester Young was the pitcher. I thought this vague guy being a pitcher, that must have been some game. When Shorty, my first husband, was with Tommy Dorsey they had baseball games. And Harry James was this corny guy that took everything so seriously, and they came to play the Dorsey band in Bernardsville at Tommy Dorsey's palatial estate. And they were kind of kidding around, the Dorsey band. But Harry James' band were grimly serious. They had uniforms, and oh boy, you know. And our team was kidding around. And Ziggy Elman got up at bat and he had this big cigar in the way, it discombobulated the pitcher. Well there aren't any more big bands so there aren't any more ball games, but I guess that was kind of big in those days.

MR: Was there a strong sense of competition between the big bands at that time?

JB: Yes there was. And stealing musicians from each other was very big. When I started listening to music, they were set — I mean Ellington's band was Ellington's band and somebody else was something else. But I don't know when the stealing of musicians and trading and moving around, but good night, just while I was married to Shorty, he moved around to a number of bands. He had been in, when I came into his life he had been in Jimmy Dorsey's — well he'd been in Ben Pollack's band, and Jimmy Dorsey, and Bob Crosby, and then when I married him he was with Gene Krupa and had switched from Dixieland to this style that he'd heard that just got him crazy and that was Roy Eldridge. And you hear these early Jazz at the Philharmonic records, you think it's Roy and it's Shorty, sounding exactly like him. And of course he was this blonde kewpee doll with these big goo-goo eyes, blue eyes and a little turned up nose and everything. He looked like a Campbell Soup baby. He looked nothing like Roy. But he tried to dress like him

and he got a car like him, and the payments I think were like $85 a month, and he was only making $85 a week. It was pretty dicey. And he was standing next to his car in this costume, and Bobby Burnett came by. He was a trumpet player with Charlie Barnet. And he said, "Shorty, what happened?" Shorty said, "man when I change I change all the way." So here he was playing like Roy.

MR: Roy was one of the biggest competitors in the jam sessions.

JB: That's right. Yeah. In my movie as a matter of fact, I think it's Hank Jones says that you think he's not going to play any higher and then he does. Yeah, oh yes. He had to kill everybody with this business.

MR: Now you, you were pretty into the Ellington band too.

JB: That was my main band, and so when Bob and I came into each other's lives there were two emerging — the great marriage of the Ellingtons and the Basies. Yes. I met Ellington the night I graduated from prep school. And that was in June of 1936. And we were all dressed up in party clothes, you know it was graduation night. And he said, "where do you want to go?" Well Ellington was playing a two week engagement at the Congress Hotel in Chicago. So I said, "I'd like to go and hear Ellington." Because I'd had all his records. So we got there and my date said, "shall we ask them over to have a glass of champagne?" I said, "oh, wow, yes, let's do." So he came over and he stood at the table and he said, "Miss Enzinger, what are your plans?" Oh, first I said, "I'm so thrilled to meet you," I said, "you and Stravinsky are my two favorite composers." He said, "I'm jealous of Stravinsky." I mean he was like this all the time. So I told him I was going to Vassar. So he said, "oh well that's not far from where I live, we must get together, now make sure we do." And I said, "yes." So I got to school, and my roommate, we were getting acquainted and I brought all these recordings with me, and I said, "we'll have music." And she said, "well that's great, while we study." So then I told her about meeting Ellington, and she said, "well I hope you're going to take him up on it." I said, "oh Smith, how can I?" She said, "I'll bet you you haven't got nerve to do it." And I said, "what's the bet?" She said, "well, if you don't go you have to give me this cashmere sweater." And I said, "what if I do go?" She said, "then you'll have had the experience and you'll win." So that was enough. And can you believe he was in the phone book? I looked him up in the phone book. Now you could get on the train at Poughkeepsie, and the next stop, I think there was one stop at Harman and the next one was 125th Street. So we were going in all the time to the Apollo Theater. I got to hear all the great bands and see all the wonderful acts in 1936 and 7. It was the golden period. So I just went, it was about 2 or 2:30 in the afternoon and it really tells you about innocence. You know it really pays to be innocent. You just walk into these things. It was heaven. And I knocked on the door, and this elderly gentleman came to the door, "yes can I help you?" It was

Ellington's father. And he only had lived with him I think during a very brief period. It was fewer than six months. But that was just that little gap there that he'd moved into Ellington's apartment. So he said, I said, "he told me to come by." He said, "fine, I'll go get him." Well I mean the curtains were drawn, it was like midnight in there you know, 'cause it was to them, midnight. It was very dark in the living room.

MR: They were kind of night owls.

JB: That's it. So Ellington finally came in, in a stunning silk robe, and very courtly, "how lovely to see you." I said, "well you did say to come by." I looked like, well I can't say co-ed, 'cause we only had girls and boys schools then, but you know I had the little bowler hat and the polo coat and the little white gloves and everything. And so years later, Bob Bach, my late husband, was doing a special on Ellington for PBS. And he got what they call sort of "witness spots" you know for people that had known him, and told little highlights about their lives. And of course I had nine million adventures, I couldn't wait to get on. But how they did it was there was this director kneeling, sort of our of camera range, asking questions. And he asked me the oddest questions. And one he asked me was had Ellington ever mentioned an opera to me. Now it turns out that, that was a line he used with everybody you know. He'd meet you and he'd say, "you are so right for a part in my opera," he said. "It has to be an intelligent handsome man with great poise and I can just see you in this role, and I don't know whether you'd be uncomfortable singing, it doesn't have to be a singing role." He would lay it on with a trowell. And I mean dogs and cats, women, children, men, anybody, he didn't care. A friend of mine, Casper Reardon, the jazz harpist, he told him he had a part, you know he was to write a part in for a harpist. So I guess they thought they'd get some juicy story from me. So I said, "yes, that first day that I went to see him he told me all about this opera he was working on, but no he didn't say he was going to put me in the opera" he said, "Marian Anderson." But you see how smart he was? That would impress a little college girl more. "Marian Anderson's going to be in an opera."

MR: He was never at a loss, was he?

JB: Oh, please. I had a list of, I did a little talk about this, up in Ottawa at the, there's an International Ellington Society that meets every year in a different country. And a few years ago it was up in Ottawa. And they knew that I'd known him forever. And they said "do you want to just talk about the personal side?"— because I don't claim to be a great musicologist. I said, "sure, because I've got a bundle of stories." And I'm telling these stories about what a jive turkey he was you know. How he'd put you on. And those people didn't think it was too funny. Because see he's sacred. It's like, they're like Moonies. And I mean the fingernail clippings and the —

MR: They didn't want to hear that side of him.

JB: No, no. It didn't go over too well. But I had a lot of funny stories.

MR: Musically, what was the biggest difference between Basie and Ellington?

JB: Well Ellington got to my gut you know, all those passioned, romantic, beautiful things. And I was an only child and I was home alone a lot, and you know you put the phonograph on and you just — I think it's when certain things enter your realm. You know your pores are open when you're developing a teenager. When you're 17, 18, you're very receptive. And you find that the reason Scott Fitzgerald had whatever obsession he had, I guess he was, it was important to kind of do social climbing at a certain age in his life. And I think a lot of these consuming interests start up when you're in that very vulnerable period. You're sort of responding. So Ellington really got to me all during my teen years. All those recordings. And to this day I have one ally, this fellow Bobby Short that I mentioned, because he's a little younger than I but he was very precocious. And he listened to the same records I did. And boy we take off and we sing them together you know, all the parts, all the solos. And Basie was just happy music, and lively and —

MR: A little more dance oriented perhaps?

JB: Absolutely. Very swift and wonderful. Yeah, Ellington had more interesting colors.

MR: At that time, jazz was the popular music, isn't that right?

JB: Yes. You know my first job I was a society reporter in Chicago on first *The Tabloid*, which is now known as the *Sun Times*, and then the Hearst paper. And everybody in my age group was coming out. So there were debutante parties. And it was perfect for me, because they all had wonderful bands. The first time I ever heard Ray Nance was covering a debut of a girl named Bird Littlefield in Chicago. She had a coming out party at the Blackstone Hotel. And I think there was sort of a balcony around the ballroom and off of which were the ladies cloak room and different places. I was in there taking my gloves off and I heard this sound coming up. And I went out and hung over the balcony. It was so beautiful. It was Ray Nance playing, he called it "Kitty on Toast," it was a variation of "Honeysuckle Rose." My gosh, it was the most gorgeous thing I'd ever heard. And there were big bands that played for — Sheila Cuttahee had Duke Ellington's orchestra. That was about 1938 I think. And I was with a fellow called Dodge from I guess Grosse Pointe, Michigan. I guess he was a famous Dodge, I don't know, he was my date that night. And he said, it came midnight and they'd break you know and have breakfast. That was a big thing in those days, these balls, you'd have some kind of midnight supper or something. He said, "shall we go up and sit with the band?" And they were sitting on the balcony. I said, "yes we will." So we went and sat there, and that's how I've met my dream prince of all time, that I've never gotten over, Lawrence Brown. And he was my favorite. And so I sat next to him and we talked. I did a memorial for him

at St. Peter's Church here. And he died in California, but I thought I'd do it here, because I had a lot of stuff on him. I had slides and photographs and a lot of details. And I said at the memorial that he always looked like Rudolph Valentino to me. And I said if Rudolph Valentino could play the trombone, he'd probably sound like Lawrence.

MR: Yeah, he had sounds —

JB: Oh, it was so romantic. So while I was doing all this, somebody showed up with a vase with roses and put it on the lectern or whatever you call it, the pulpit. I said, "roses, this is like Rudolph Valentino." And it was some woman's name signed to the roses, I have no idea who it was, and so that was that. Bobby Short was a little boy who was a kiddie performer. And when he went out to California he moved in with you know, little colored kids, or any kids on the road I guess had trouble finding accommodations. And he moved in with the family of Lawrence's brother, Harold Brown. And so he stole some pictures for me. So I have pictures of Lawrence at an early age.

MR: You just started to touch on a subject that I find interesting and that is the racial thing that was happening at that time, with this music and the fans, and how did that kind of balance —

JB: Very, very heartbreaking in a way, but somehow I mean as you look back it was terrible, but it was a given. And I was interviewed by somebody from the Black Entertainment Network, she came to my house. And she said, "you don't look like a jazz groupie, to be following the band." Well boy I was. I was the first jazz groupie. I mean I'd hear Ellington was playing in Rock Island, Illinois, and if I wasn't doing anything that day, I'd get on the train and just go and hear the band. So I heard him quite a lot. They played at the Sherman Hotel for, was it a four week period or maybe a little longer. And Harry Lim, the jazz critic from *Batavia Java* by way of Holland was living in Chicago at the time. And he and I went every night to hear Ellington. But then we would go out afterward, and you didn't go out in midtown Chicago, you went to the south side. There was a drug store out there called The Ritz Drugstore. And they had something like 27 flavors of ice cream. So we'd all sit around, the whole band and Ellington, and we'd be dipping in each other's ice cream, very unsanitary. Ellington coined a word, "seagulling." And he said that's what you do when you steal something off someone else's plate. And he said, they had their own, as you know, private car. They had to travel that way because they couldn't stay in hotels. And I think they had their own diner too. And he said at mealtime, the master seagull doesn't order anything for dinner, he just orders a service plate, and he just walks down the aisle and says, "what do you have that goes good with my dinner," and helps himself. But Bobby tells me a lot that's like, you know I guess it's like childbirth. You forget all the terrible stuff. I don't remember it. But Bobby said, "don't you remember, we had to meet in the stairwell and all that stuff?" He said it was

really kind of bad. But I remember a few moments of anxiety. Lee Wiley was living in the Rockefeller Apartments, not far from where we are now. And it's kind of a tony building. I don't know if they called it the Rockefeller Apartments, but it's across from the Museum of Modern Art. And she had invited the gang from Nick's to come over. And she suddenly said, "[gasps] Zutty Singleton — they won't let him through the lobby." And I said, "let me handle this." And my mother was sort of a Grand Dame and she'd "brook no nonsense" as we say. And I suddenly became my mother. And I said, "give me the doorman, please." And I said, what's his name, James? I said, "James," I said, "this is Miss Wiley's apartment. She's expecting some guests. Will you see that they're ushered up right away, and make sure that Mr. Singleton comes. You'll recognize him. He's colored. Thank you very much. Goodbye." Because you know, to have to go up the service elevator kind of breaks your spirit and that happened all the time.

MR: Even we've heard, and I've read too about some places where the audience would be separated by a rope.

JB: Yes, or worse. When we were in Denver, Shorty Sherock and this mixed band, we became very friendly with Paul Quinichette and his wife, and his mother who a was darling and attractive woman who was a businesswoman. I think she did real estate or something like that. And so one night we were going to the movies, Paul and his wife I think Juanita was her name, and Shorty and I. And we got to the box office, and Shorty said, "four tickets." And we started to go in and Paul said, "we'll see you later," and they started to go up the stairs to the balcony. I said, "no, no, no, we don't want to go up the balcony, come on." And he said, "no, we'll see you later, honestly." And he was trying to gloss over it. And I said, "what is this? Let me see the manager." You know and I was so objectionable. And the next day his mother called me up, Billie. She said, "Jean, up until about two years ago, we couldn't even go in that theater." She said, "you've really ruined things for making such a scene." So and that was Denver, that wasn't even the south. Marie Bryant, who is in the film that I'm showing with "A Great Day in Harlem," the film is called "Jammin' The Blues." And it features Lester Young and Harry Edison and a lot of wonderful people. And she's the dancer in it and she sings "Sunny Side of the Street." And it was up for an Oscar in 1944, and so I thought it was a nice companion piece to my film, which was up for an Oscar in 1995. So I was very fond of her. And she was a light skinned person with freckles, you know that look? And she had never been south, but she was traveling around with the Ellington band, doing a little act. She did kind of a take of Moms Mabley and then she danced and did a lot of stuff. So she said she got to St. Louis and the band all stayed out in some part of town, and she stayed with them, and she noticed that a movie was showing in downtown St. Louis that she wanted to go to, so she got in a cab, an African-American cab, and she said, "take me to the

Bijou Theater." And he said, "oh well I'll have to take you to within a couple of blocks. I'm not going up there." She said, "don't be silly, this is America, I want to go to the theater." He said, "I'm sorry lady," you know, "you'll have to get out and walk the last couple of blocks." So she thought, well the heck with him, you know, I don't believe in this stuff, I'm from Chicago. So she gets to the theater, buys the ticket, goes in, sits down in the front, starts watching the movie and it's great but she can't keep her mind on the movie because she's thinking, wow, I'm getting away with murder. She couldn't stand it anymore. And she went back to the entrance and said to the head usher, "excuse me?" He said, "yes, Miss?" She said, "do I look colored to you?" He said, "well, no." She said, "well I am," and she flew out of the theater and ran all the way home, and that was like her moment of triumph that she pulled one. I mean it must have been really crazy for entertainers, you know, who had this—

MR: Once they were on stage, it was okay, but "come in the back door."

JB: Yeah. It's terrible. So I guess I did all my listening on their turf. Well, no, oh, John Kirby's band played in the Pump Room of the Ambassador East Hotel, which was then the toniest hotel in Chicago. Beautiful. And the room was exquisite, with dark blue walls and white woodwork, and sconces and it was very stylish. And they'd had a lot of good bands in there — Teddy Wilson was there and at any rate, when Kirby played, they looked so marvelous. They had tail suits, full dress suits, but everything was in white. White tie and white tail suits and everything. The cast was Russell Procope on saxophone and Buster Bailey on clarinet. Billy Kyle was the piano player, and Charlie Shavers wrote the arrangements and played trumpet, and Kirby was the bassist. The drummer was a man named O'Neil Spencer, who also sang. So one day somebody checked in the hotel. It'd been in the papers, her name was Edith Rodgers Dahl and her husband, Whitey Dahl had been a flyer and was shot down by Franco it was during the war in Spain, and was in prison. And so she had sent a picture of herself. She was some tootsie with blonde hair, she played the violin in vaudeville. She sent a picture of herself to Franco and that was in all the papers. She was trying to get him out of prison. Meanwhile, O'Neil was apprehended on the stairs, I think coming from her room or going up to her room. And they said, "what are you doing?" He said, "I'm Miss Dahl's arranger." And they roared with laughter. They said, "this man can't read music." It was quick thinking. So there was a lot of sneaking around the stairs I guess in those days.

MR: Who were some of your favorite characters, players, in the Basie groups over the years?

JB: Well of course Lester was my Dream Prince of all time. Buck Clayton. I used to say to Harry Lim, "you like Buck Clayton?" "Yeah," he says "I always remember John Hammond's line was many times I have heard him but always muted." So I thought he was married to Singsee, but it seems I think they were just live-in companions for a

number of years. She was adorable. And she probably decided she wanted to get married and so she took off with Billy Kyle. I said to Harry Lim, "what do you think Buck Clayton said?" He said, "he probably took his mute out at that point." I don't know, I was just crazy about that band. Well there was a period in I guess it was in the 50s when they were playing at Birdland, and it was just like — well it was like going to church, I mean you just went regularly, you know you'd be marked absent if you weren't there. I was very friendly with Dorothy Kilgallen, who was on my husband's television show, "What's My Line," so we were a foursome. We used to go there regularly, many times every week just to check in all the time. And of course Joe Williams was our Dream Prince. And that man has the most marvelous total recall. I wish, as I'm getting on years, names are slipping away and dates and everything else. But he just, you can sit him down — I was walking along Central Park South one evening, and I ran into him. And he said, "I want to get some ice cream." And I said, "we're right at Rumpelmeyer's, let's go in, I'll come with you, I'd like some." We went and we sat there. We must have sat there for a couple of hours, over a sundae, an ice cream sundae. Because he was reminding me of all the places in Chicago in the south side, where everything was, who the owner was, who worked there, it was just so marvelous. And I've seen a video of a show like that in Los Angeles with Ernie Andrews. And he, but he's in a car and he's driving along and he says, "here's where Black Dot McGee's was" and here's where something else was. But you could do that with Joe. It'd be heaven just to show everything about Chicago.

MR: Now he got his start in Chicago, right?

JB: He sure did, yeah.

MR: And when you saw him with Basie, that was the time when he had the hit "Every Day?"

JB: And "The Comeback" I loved you know. It was so marvelous. It was sensational, and he still sounds good. I love it when singers retain their vigor and their vocal qualities, it's just so thrilling.

MR: Oh, that's great. How did you get into the radio production business?

JB: Let's see what happened? Well I needed a job and my husband, Bob Bach, was producing "What's My Line." He thought it up, little knowing it was going to take off and be a 27 year run. And that's how we became so friendly with Dorothy and Dick. So he came home one day and he said, "gee we're thinking of reviving 'Luncheon at Sardi's' which was a terrible program," and he said, "Arlene said they came to her," Arlene Francis, and he said, "she needs someone to produce it, do you want to do it?" So I wasn't doing anything and I thought well that's fine. It was just shortly before that that I really was trying to think what the heck would be a good job for me considering my skills such as they were, not much, and my information, which was considerable on a lot of subjects. I have wild curiosity about everything. I was talking to somebody who advises

you and I said, “here are the things” I thought that she’d just give me a — like when you get weighed and they give you a ticket and it say “you will travel” you know, the little wing see? But before they could figure out what I should do I got this job. And it was marvelous. Because I didn’t do much about jazz, Arlene was not too musical. But I was interesting in overthrowing the government at the time so that was my platform. Arlene was willing to go along with anything. One day she said, “you’re my puppet.” No it was the other way around, I beg your pardon, she said, “I’m your puppet.” I said, “well Arlene, I mean you know, it’s your program if you object—” She used to get sore because I kept handing her the same question all the time: “why do men like war?” It’s a dynamite question. When you’re at a dinner party sometime, toss that out. People either get terribly defensive and they say “what do you mean” you know, “we’re a peace loving nation.” Or else they start, they say, “well maybe he wants to get away from the old battle ax.” There’s a lot of latitude there. So anyway, because of my galloping curiosity about everything, and it was a great opportunity to meet all my favorites, you know Bucky [Buckminster] Fuller I got very friendly with him, and political people, we were forever getting politicians on, and authors. And authors are great because at least they’ve got one subject adjusted, and if you’re lucky they haven’t forgotten it. Once in a while, somebody would come on whose book had been ghostwritten. And they’d be absolutely at a loss, and that was kind of difficult. But it worked pretty well.

MR: It’s kind of a high pressure situation, every day having to come up with something fresh I would think.

JB: Yes, absolutely. And the reading of course was a killer, because Arlene never had time to do anything, so I did all the reading. And it got so toward the end that I would say to the publishers, because they knew that we sold books. We had the number one rating on the air and the station was easy to find, right in the middle of the dial, and the loudest station on the dial. And so they’d say, “Oh Jean, this is right up your alley. This book is marvelous. It’s an overview of—” I’d say, “what’s the magic number?” If it was over 300 pages I’d kind of, I figured, I can’t get this read in a night. I did take a reading course, yeah, but not every day. But I did have some jazz people on. But you know a lot of jazz people were horrible guests. Ellington was the worst. And as well as I knew him, and I knew I’d be a better guest talking about him than he was. He was sort of stilted and didn’t give very much, and laughed a lot. Everything was discounted with a laugh. Well Arlene had the same problem. She’d have a question that she didn’t quite believe in, like, “why do men like war?” And then she’d nullify it by going [laughs] like I’m really kidding. So he did a lot of that. So I was out in Milwaukee with a bunch of Ellington fans. And one of them had taped this show. And he said, “what was wrong with Arlene that day?” I said,

"it wasn't only Arlene, it was Ellington. The two of them were jiving each other and you didn't get anything. It was not one of his finer moments.

MR: That's interesting because he was so smooth and debonair in person but it didn't translate.

JB: But he held information back and he didn't tell the truth you know. When I was 18, I was a size 18. I was fat, I was awkward, I had no poise — well I still don't have too much poise, but I was really uugh, it was terrible. And he said to me, because he knew he had me going, I believed everything he said. He said, "you know I'd like you to do something for me." Oh by now I had a job on a newspaper, that was it. So he told everybody that Eleanor Roosevelt and I were his two favorite writers. I thought gee, that's great, he likes my writing. So he said, "I wish you'd write a lyric to 'Sophisticated Lady.'" I said, "I think there is a lyric to 'Sophisticated Lady.'" He said, "yeah but it's not right." He said, "you see you're my idea of a real sophisticated lady." And I absolutely believed him. So crazy. He would say things, as I say, as outrageous as these compliments, and I bought every one. But most people did. They wanted to believe it. And then if it got too crazy, and you'd say, "oh come on, you've got to be kidding." He'd say, "well I know it sounds ridiculous, it sounds too far fetched," but he said, "I have to say it because it's the truth." He said, "that's me, Honest Ellington." He's just told you that he knew you were walking because the walls were beginning to tingle that you were going to walk in the room you know. And so Honest Ellington, you know? I can't keep it back. I have to tell the truth.

MR: I hope you're not tired of talking about your film.

JB: Oh, no, I love talking about my film.

MR: It must have been a labor of love, and I mean it's clear that you're very passionate about this music.

JB: Well you see you've put your finger on it. Very profound. I went to a panel of documentarians at Kansas City when I was out there. And somebody raised the question of money. You know, is it profitable? And they all started laughing. They're all experienced. They said, "you don't go into the documentary business to make money," they said, "you're driven by passion." You know, Voters Rights in Mississippi or some great medical quest or something like that. So I guess that's what really— also, I didn't know what the heck I was getting into. I didn't know beans about making a movie, which is just as well, because had I known all the downside, I'd have probably reconsidered. I was well into it before I found out that you have to pay for everything. That was, oh, what a blow. I mean it was really terrible.

MR: You mean, like what, besides the obvious.

JB: Like the music rights, which is the worst, and a lot of other stuff. Stills — I thought I'd just borrow some stills from photographers who are friends of mine, and they all wanted

$200 and stuff, it was terrible. I was filming people, I got a camera crew, and when I was able to locate people who are still alive who'd been there that day, I would do what you and I are doing and have a conversation. And I was well into it when Catherine Altman, who is married to Robert Altman, the great film maker, she's one of my best friends. And she said, "Jean, I really think you could use some professional help." Well I was a little annoyed. I thought, wait a minute, Catherine, I'm doing this. I thought you interviewed and then took the end of that tape and then you glued it to the top of the next one and then you did the next one. I thought that was editing. So she introduced me to a man named Matthew Seig, and you'll see his credit on the end of the film. He's my co-producer now. And he knows jazz up one side and down the other, and he works for Altman and he knows budgets and insurance and contracts and all that stuff. So he sat me down and he started to explain all this to me. He said, "well we'll have to get an editor." I thought I was going to do the editing. Boy are we lucky I didn't do it. It would have been the worst. And she was brilliant. He got me the best editor in the world [Susan Peehl]. And rent a studio and rent equipment and so it became kind of a —

MR: Yes. We've been thinking about that same subject ourselves.

JB: It's a brute. But the worst in the music clearance. And there are 23 musical numbers in this movie. And there's something called a "most favored nations." And that means whichever publisher gets the most money gets matched by all the others. So we were going along trying to cut corners. Now we had to clear for overseas cable, regular television, theaters, festivals, all kinds of stuff. And so we shaved a few years off and did this and did that to make everything kind of come together, until the last tune. And that was Lester Young playing "Polka Dots and Moonbeams." And it was gorgeous. And this horrible woman at Bourne Publishers, she's the granddaughter of the founder, asked for a hundred thousand dollars. Well I got furious. And I figured she wanted to play with me, you know, that she'd come down two thousand and I'd go up one thousand from five thousand, which I'd planned to pay her. I mean it was just awful. And so we took it out of the film. But I felt we put something else in which worked even better, with "Stardust" and it was kind of the repeat of something earlier in the film. But I was talking to Gerry Mulligan's first wife, Arlene, whose father was Lou Brown of DeSilva, Brown and Henderson. And she said, "boy if they did anything like that about my father's songs, I'd be furious," because she wants them played you know. I said I'll bet the widow VanHeusen doesn't know that they're doing this to her late husband's music. And so someday, justice will prevail. Oh, listen, I've got a friend who made the best documentary I've ever seen on Ellington, and you'll never see it unless you caught it that one time it was on PBS. Because the man who has all the Ellington music that Ruth got rid of, I mean Ellington left her the catalogue—

MR: She sold the rights?

JB: Yes, she sold to a man named Fox. And he's like this person at Bourne. He wants the moon. And this poor guy, I was going to get him before I got Matthew, to see if he'd want to work on the film. And I never could — I saw him once and he said, "yeah it sounded wonderful." But I never could get him on the phone. He always had a cold or he was having a nervous breakdown. Because he's got this treasure and he can't—

MR: That's too bad because it stifles things to come out of it that might come later.

JB: Yeah. And this was such a good piece on Ellington. But you couldn't, there's no way you could do it without music, although I think he should figure something out, because it's so full of information. It's just great.

MR: Well it must have been a nice compliment and a thrill for this *Life* Magazine shoot that just happened this week. For those of you who don't have the copy yet, I'm not sure when it will come out.

JB: It's not coming out until January '96, and probably the end. I think it has something to do with Black History Month, so it'll be around.

MR: *Life* Magazine has re-staged the photo, and then done a new photo for 50 years from now I guess.

JB: Well who knows? I mean already we're thinking of people that should have been added and that it's going to happen. The poor guy who did it. He's been a basket case all summer long. First he wanted to line up all the people who were in the movie, who are still alive, who were gettable. And the only one that escaped his grasp was Sonny Rollins, who's in Japan and couldn't get out. But they flew in from Italy they flew Gerry and Franca Mulligan in from Italy. They flew Chubby and his wife, Chubby Jackson and his wife and Horace Silver in from California. Johnny Griffin came in from France, they flew him in and put him up. They flew in Art Farmer from Austria, Vienna Austria. So it was a very elaborate thing. And then everybody posed on the steps, as you probably heard, of the brownstone, where the original picture had been taken. And Gordon Parks took the picture. And it's very moth eaten, because there was just a handful of people left. Including the little kid that was sitting next to Basie.

MR: Oh, really?

JB: It was so sweet, yeah.

MR: How did they know?

JB: Well I found him, because I put an ad in the *Amsterdam News* which is a Harlem newspaper, with the photograph. See I loved all this part of producing the movie, tracking people down, loved that. And I said, "do you remember this photo?" I said, "it ran in *Esquire*" and I told the date and it was taken in the summer of '58. "Were you there? Do you know anyone who was? If so call this number." And I had a separate telephone with

an answering machine attached. And people started checking in. And one was the little boy sitting next to Basie. So that was nice. Basie sat down when everybody else was standing, because I think his legs gave out. And in later years of course he was in this wheelchair that he drove himself. It was kind of marvelous. But the other person that decided to sit down was Willie the Lion Smith. And he's so big and pompous and arrogant you know. And he was standing there with this man who is half his size, Lucky Roberts had his arm around him and then in the last picture, he wanders off to the steps of the brownstone, just out of the frame, so he didn't get in the picture in *Esquire*. He must have been kicking himself. Too bad. But he's in the home movies that Mona Hinton shot that I've used in my movies. So you see him, you know, standing, very pompous and cute.

MR: There's two marvelous people, for you, Milt and Mona.

JB: Can you believe it? He's America's sweetheart. I mean his feet never touch the ground. He's in this festival and that jazz party and they yank him back and forth overseas, he's in Switzerland, he's in Texas, he's here he's there. They never — well that was part of my problem, trying to get that footage. What made me decide to do the movie was him telling me about this home movie that she'd taken. So I just figured I'd better step on it because these people are dropping like flies. Lawrence Brown had just died that August, and Roy Eldridge had died the January before. So I thought I'd better get moving. So I started in without having seen the home movie. And then after a while I got quite a bit of stuff in the box and we got Sue on the case and she started doing her weaving and knitting and editing, and I still hadn't seen the thing. And I got a little panicked and I enlisted a fellow called David Berger. Do you know him?

MR: Yes, he did Milt's books.

JB: Yes he did the books. He's the one that went down in that basement, which must be like Fibber McGee's closet, and found a lot of wonderful photographs and got Milt to caption them so they knew who they were, and so I said to him, he teaches sociology in Philadelphia. I said, "get two of your Phi Beta students and go down there and look at every piece of celluloid you can find." And they finally found the film.

MR: How much actual footage was it? Time-wise?

JB: It's only 11 minutes. But Sue picked out little pieces. And a lot of it was damaged too, I mean she used as much as she could. But I said to Milt, "do you mean to say the photograph comes to life?" And he says, "yeah, you could say that." And it does. Because as a static picture, it's black and white. And then when it comes to life there's color. And that's a nice touch I think.

MR: We'll move back to the Basie band for just a minute. There's been — people always talk about their rhythm section, and what made that so special.

JB: You know that rhythm section really characterized different bands. If they played that style, that was their ideal. And when Shorty Sherock got his big band and got a date at Glen Island Casino, his rhythm section were Basie fans. As a matter of fact, Nat Pierce, you may have heard of him, he was a noted arranger and pianist, and before he died they formed a, what do they called it, Juggernaut band.

MR: The Juggernaut band, in fact we talked to Frank Capp in Los Angeles.

JB: Oh did you? Well Nat I think this was his first professional job. Stanley Kay, the drummer with Shorty Sherock's orchestra was in a record store in Boston buying some Basie records. And before he got, they had little booths in those days. You went in a little glass-enclosed booth and there were individual machines, you could play records. So as he hadn't even put his records on the turntable, and he heard the very ones that he was buying from the next booth. He thought, I've got to meet this guy. And he went in and he said, "you've got the same records I have." And the man said, "oh I do?" Stanley said, "are you a musician by any chance?" He said, "what's your instrument." "Piano." Stanley said, "are you free tonight? We need a piano player." And so Nat came on the band. And so there was Stanley and I guess they brainwashed the bassist to be in their camp. But the brass section were Italian chaps, and they played a different way. And I thought it was like you were having a race war on the stage every night. They were out of sync. They weren't moving like the rhythm section. It was funny. But that was Shorty's band. Well it was wartime you know. You took what you could get. Although Brew Moore was in the sax section. He had an interesting band.

MR: Do you still see the Basie band in their present form?

JB: Yeah, I think they're not — they're getting away from it and, God knows the Ellington band, I mean they rarely, they're way off someplace. They're not in the — the old dyed-in-the-wool fans, they want to hear that stuff. I'll tell you who plays like Basie is Diva, the all-girl band if you've heard them. Because Stanley Kay is the founding father of that band, and he manages them, and he writes little things that sound like Basie. He has a take off on Four Brothers. He calls it "Three Sisters and a Cousin." Saxophones get up. The only thing about them, they're wonderful and they sound like Basie, but they play too loud. And it's because they're females I guess. They want to show they can do it.

MR: I like some of the musicians that have talked about the fact that when they were playing back in the 30s and 40s that the amplification was not an issue really. So they played perhaps a little more attuned to each other. If you were in the back row and you couldn't hear the soloist, then you were playing too loud, and it wasn't a matter of turn up his microphone—

JB: You are absolutely my man on that. I absolutely agree with you. I went to a concert of Ellington music in Milwaukee at the Performing Arts Center, which is a gorgeous,

modern, I guess they do symphony concerts there and so forth. And Gunther Schuller was conducting. And just before the concert started, he walked around the stage and pulled out every plug. He said, "we'll have none of this." And it was just wonderful. God it sounded like the way it was supposed to sound.

MR: We had a similar story from, I forget who told it now, about Illinois Jacquet doing the same thing in Europe. The sound man went through the whole thing, set the levels, and then Illinois said, "now take all your faders and turn them down 50 percent, and don't touch them again."

JB: Yes. Well Chubby Jackson has a rule about the basses. Because they've suddenly, it's the democratization in action, you know, democracy in action. They all, everybody wants to be heard, and so they turn that thing up very high. And Chubby said, "when it goes past this direction, it's too loud." And yeah, I hate amplification. It's not what we were used to. It's not the natural sound, it's something else.

MR: Right. I guess if you're playing big stadiums or auditoriums, there's a certain level.

JB: Well but if you're playing Carnegie Hall, you know when Carnegie Hall got re-done, one of the first bands I heard there was Basie. And I was embarrassed. I was with somebody that I dragged. I said, "we'll go and hear this." It sounded like mud. There was no definition. It just all overlapped and blurred. And they just had the sound on too loud. It was terrible.

MR: The hall was made to be—

JB: Well of course, yes.

MR: An opera singer could fill it up. Yeah, it's interesting. What's your take on jazz today and the future?

JB: Gee I don't know. I have people I always go and see — Ahmad Jamal, I'm crazy about him. I would like to hear some big bands occasionally. Gosh, Jimmy Heath came by the table yesterday at the *Life* thing and said that he has a big band playing at the Iridium Room. I thought he said it was just last night. And I was too tired, but I think it's for the whole week. So and he's wonderful. But I said something, and I suppose I shouldn't have said it to a newspaper, and it's not a very original line, but I said the people today they have wonderful chops, and they're well schooled you know, and it's like the four minute mile, they can do stuff better than the people before them, skillfully. But they're standing on the shoulders of these people in my photograph. You know, Dizzy and Mingus and Lester and Coleman Hawkins. I mean they've taken off from that. They're great, but I'd give anything if I could hear Herschel Evans again.

MR: He died awful young, didn't he?

JB: Yeah. Too soon for me. I'm not sure, as I say, I'm not sure I ever, I must have heard him in person but don't remember.

MR: Well I guess there's not nearly as many places for the young musicians just out of school to go and really hone their craft.

JB: Well unless they're in New York City, I mean there's just so much music in New York, and the other places it's just dried up, although I'm told that there's certain pockets around the country. Certainly not Los Angeles. There's very little out there. When Leonard Feather moved out there, I think he got a job with the *L.A. Times*, presumably to write a lot about jazz. There wasn't a heck of a lot. I mean one person had opened and then that would be a big event. Well the distances are great. But what's terrible here is that it's, they go on so darn late and it's very expensive, so you can't do a bunch of clubs in a night. And then there are these small, I mean it will be the star and rhythm. Just little quartets. And in the olden days you got a little better mixture.

MR: Did you make the scene at 52nd Street?

JB: Oh did I? That was living. Because you'd go in one door and in another, and just on and on. You didn't have to have cab fare. You just walked from one to another. And as I recall, I guess there must have been a minimum at the table, it was probably fifty cents or a dollar at most. But you could hang out at the bar. It was something else. I've never seen a photo with the signs out of the people I wanted to see all at once, but you know, occasionally you'll see photos and it will be Don Byas and Stuff Smith and Erroll Garner started on the downtown side of the street closest to Fifth Avenue. And I stuck my nose in and I thought, oh that's cocktail piano and I came out again. And of course when I think I could have heard him probably the first night, I didn't realize how marvelous he was. I did later on. But that was, well a lot of people got started there.

MR: We had occasion to see a group in Los Angeles called the Statesmen of Jazz. I think they're coming to New York pretty soon. It's a nice idea that they're trying to promote, that you have to be over 65 to be in the group.

JB: Jane Jarvis is the pianist yes. Oh, she's crazy about that group.

MR: And one of the things that they try to do, every time they play a concert is during that day they go into a school.

JB: What a good idea. Yeah. It's interesting. My movie ran for about nine weeks in New York, seven shows a day. It was a sell-out. I mean we wiped up the floor with "Hoop Dreams" that was in the same theater. They could only play three shows a day so they weren't getting the turnover that we were. And friends of mine who would go felt that they had to report to me on the demographics of the audience. So they'd call up and they'd say, "well there were quite a few young people, college-age people, and they seemed to have brought their parents who were probably into folk music or rock & roll or something. But of course there were a lot of old timers like us that were from the big

band era. But mostly it was people new to jazz that are college-age. I mean I hope it's true. And us senior people. And it's that middle group we've got to get to now.

MR: Well that's one reason that I think it's important that we get stories on tape so that people can find out what it was really like.

JB: Boy if you could have had a microphone, you mentioned 52nd Street, everybody would go play a set and then they'd go 'round the corner on Sixth Avenue on the southeast corner around facing Sixth Avenue to a place called the White Rose. And boy that was like you died and went to heaven. All your dream people were in there, you know, Coleman Hawkins would be having a drink with whoever, Nat King Cole. It was just marvelous, that era. And to think we took them all for granted, you know. Nobody, that's one of the reasons I made the movie, to tell you the truth. Nobody saved anything from that period — letters, programs, when I think of programs and photographs that I had from then. I'm as bad as the musicians. But the musicians are the worst. They never save a darn thing. None of them had saved the photograph that ran in *Esquire* magazine that inspired the film. So the first thing I'd say was, "do you have a copy of the photo?" "Oh, no" you know, "I bought the magazine back there in '58 when it came out, but I never thought to save it." So then I'd give them a print and they'd be so thrilled. And I don't know one jazz musician that has all the records that he made. Because they're not portable. They are now, if they only had CDs, but in the days of 78s—

MR: Well, Milt would need a van.

JB: Can you believe it? I wonder what he's got? And maybe that basement would yield some — but you remember Benny Powell, he played trombone with Basie. His then-wife, I think they're not together now, called me up one day and said that she was trying to get some sort of a wive's mafia going, 'cause she figured wives saved snapshots and she was going to get in touch with a lot of wives. And that would have been a nice little archive, if she'd ever followed through. So I guess when she and Benny broke up that was the end of that project.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation.

JB: Well same here, I had a good time.

MR: We've been very glad to have Jean Bach with us, who is a film maker and walking history of jazz. And I appreciate having you wish us today.

JB: I've loved it, thank you.

MR: Thank you very much.